





BEFORE SEPTEMBER 30, THE DAY *Kantara* released, if someone had told Kannada actor-writer-director Rishab Shetty that he'd be promoting his film even a month after its release—and outside Karnataka—he'd have laughed it off. Not many outside the state had heard of him till a few months back. But in no time, the 39-year-old was offering prayers at Siddhivinayak Temple in Mumbai, and there was a trip to India Gate in Delhi, all part of the endorsements for the Hindi-dubbed version of his film, which continues to run in theatres in Mumbai. "I still don't know why it became such a big hit," says Rishab, who brilliantly essays the role of a man child-turned-rebel who finds his calling in '*boota kola*', a vibrant folk ritual from coastal Karnataka.

Seated in the office of Hombale Films in Bengaluru, Rishab is beaming. *Kantara*, with an estimated budget of Rs 16 crore, has thus far grossed nearly Rs 350 crore nationwide, and half of its collections have come from outside Karnataka. It is also the second Kannada film in 2022 to have taken the nation by storm. In April, another Hombale Films title, part II of the *K.G.F.* franchise, became a roaring hit as it gave India its new-generation 'angry young man' in Rocky, played by Yash. The action drama is the highest-grossing Indian film of 2022 and the second highest-grossing film in the country of all time.

The Kannada film industry, which for long played second fiddle to its southern neighbours (Tamil, Telugu, and even Malayalam, which doesn't have the financial clout of Chennai or Hyderabad but makes up for it with its ingenious storytelling), now finds itself in the spotlight. And it's three Shettys—Rishab, Rakshit and Raj—who have quietly propelled it to this pinnacle of success.

A LONG JOURNEY

In 2014, when Rakshit Shetty was breaking down a door and rattling off a 1980s Naseeruddin Shah line, '*phata poster nikla hero*', in his first venture *Ulidavaru Kandanthe* (2014) as a filmmaker, he was a struggling actor with a chance hit. In the frame with him was his co-star Rishab. Very few outside Karnataka